

5 Foundation Movements

Coaching cues for each pattern | Lisa McPherson, CPT

These five patterns are the backbone of the 4-Week Training Foundations program. Master the cues below and every exercise in the course will feel like a natural extension of what you already know.

01 Goblet Squat

KNEE DOMINANT

The entry point for lower-body strength. Holding the weight in front forces an upright torso and teaches the hips to load correctly before you ever touch a barbell.

KEY CUES

- > Feet shoulder-width, toes turned out 10-15 degrees
- > Brace your core before you descend — ribcage down, not flared
- > Drive your knees out over your toes throughout the movement
- > Push the floor away, squeeze glutes fully at the top

02 Romanian Deadlift

HIP HINGE

Teaches you to load the posterior chain — hamstrings and glutes — through a proper hip hinge. One of the highest-value patterns for both aesthetics and injury prevention.

KEY CUES

- > Soft bend in the knees; this is not a squat
- > Push your hips back as the weight lowers — feel the stretch in your hamstrings
- > Keep the bar or dumbbells dragging close to your legs
- > Drive hips forward to stand — squeeze glutes at lockout

03 Dumbbell Row

HORIZONTAL PULL

Builds the upper back and rear delts that balance pressing work and fix the forward-shoulder posture most of us develop from daily life.

KEY CUES

- > Brace your core and keep a neutral spine — no rotation
- > Initiate by pulling your elbow back, not shrugging your shoulder
- > Drive the elbow past your torso; pause at the top
- > Lower under control — the eccentric builds as much muscle as the pull

04 Push-Up / Dumbbell Press

HORIZONTAL PUSH

The fundamental pressing pattern. When loaded correctly, it builds chest, shoulders, and triceps while demanding core stability the entire time.

KEY CUES

- > Body in one rigid line from head to heels — no sagging hips
- > Hands just outside shoulder-width; elbows track at 45 degrees, not 90
- > Chest to the floor (push-up) or elbows below the bench (press)
- > Press until elbows are fully extended; don't lose the shoulder pack

05 Pallof Press

CORE / ANTI-ROTATION

Real core training isn't crunches — it's resisting unwanted motion. The Pallof Press teaches your trunk to stay locked while your arms move, which is exactly what the spine needs.

KEY CUES

- > Stand perpendicular to the cable or band anchor
- > Press the handle straight out from your sternum — slow and controlled
- > Resist the pull; your torso should not rotate at all
- > Hold 1-2 seconds extended, return to chest with the same control